Kerala, which seemed to be an unending procession of street dances and music that thrilled (no other word for it) the blood; or that very, very early morning in Dausa, Rajasthan, when the dark suddenly turned into bright daylight as people lit firecrackers all along the route, all at once.

Two or three hours into the walk, the yatris would cover 10 to 20 kilometres. By 9 or 10 a.m., the yatris would arrive at their day's camp. From then until the afternoon they were pretty much on their own.

Meanwhile, the other essential activities of the Yatra continued. On any given day you could see the party general secretary Jairam Ramesh holding a press conference. Or Rahul Gandhi holding meetings with diverse local groups—students, tribal communities, widows of farmers who had died by suicide, and entrepreneurs.

## A Moveable Feast

The point of the Bharat Jodo Yatra was to walk the length of the country, but of course we weren't 'only' walking. The Bharat Jodo Yatra was a moveable feast, a procession of tens of thousands, sometimes lakhs of people. It was a series of song-and-dance celebrations, of innovative sloganeering, of colourful tribal events, once even a rock concert—and, most importantly, political evangelism.

The scale of it is hard to imagine and harder still to describe. So I will resort to numbers to try and convey what it meant to be part of this juggernaut.

At the core were around 120 hand-picked Bharat yatris—Congress cadre that walked the entire journey from Kanyakumari to Kashmir. Around this core were what we know as the state yatris, the cadre that accompanied the Yatra through a particular state and 'handed over' to the next group of state yatris at the border. These typically numbered into the high hundreds. Layer on that the groups that walked the Yatra for a day or two, typically the length of a district or a large city, and the number swells to tens of thousands of participants. Now add to that the additional thousands who